

The Selling Playbook

A personal field guide to founder-led sales, synthesized from six books.

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2026-07-13

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Preface

A personal field guide to becoming a better salesperson — synthesized from six books, tuned for a founder selling their own product.

This is a private working book. It exists to make me better at selling, not to be published. I keep it in the repo so I can pull it and read it anywhere.

The six sources

#	Book	Author	What I take from it
1	Fanatical Prospecting	Jeb Blount	Build pipeline
2	SPIN Selling	Neil Rackham	Run discovery
3	The Challenger Sale	Dixon & Adamson	Create demand through insight
4	Influence	Robert Cialdini	Understand buying psychology
5	Let's Get Real or Let's Not Play	Khalsa & Illig	Sell as a trusted advisor
6	Never Split the Difference	Chris Voss	Close and negotiate

How this book is organized

It is synthesized by **sales stage**, not summarized book-by-book. Each stage pulls the right author's ideas into the moment of the deal where they matter:

1. Build the pipeline
2. Run discovery
3. Create demand through insight
4. Understand buying psychology (*a lens running under every stage*)
5. Sell as a trusted advisor
6. Close and negotiate

Preface

Read the **cheat sheet** first — it's the whole system on one page, the thing to re-read before a call. Then the **stage chapters** go deep. **Founder-led sales resources** adds material beyond the six, and **the operating cadence** turns all of it into a weekly habit.

Center of gravity

The posture underneath every stage is **trusted advisor**. I use Challenger-style insight to *create demand*, but the intent is always Khalsa's — *the client's success is the only agenda*. Insight opens eyes; it never manipulates.

The universal frame

Diagnose before you prescribe.

A doctor who prescribes before diagnosing is committing malpractice. So is a seller who pitches before diagnosing. Everything in this book is a variation on that one idea.

The One-Page Cheat Sheet

Re-read this before a call. The whole system fits here.

Stage	Book	The one move that matters	Say this
1. Build pipeline	Fanatical Prospecting	Prospect daily, no exceptions. The empty pipe is the #1 cause of failure.	*“The reason I’m calling is _____. Do you have your calendar open?”*
2. Run discovery	SPIN Selling	Ask, don’t pitch. Expand the pain with Implication questions before you ever mention your product.	<i>“What happens if this doesn’t get fixed? What’s that costing you?”</i>
3. Create demand	Challenger Sale	Teach them something surprising about their own business that reframes the problem — and leads to your strength.	<i>“Most people in your seat assume . The data actually shows .”</i>
4. Buying psychology	Influence	Seven levers running underneath every stage: reciprocity, consistency, social proof, authority, liking, scarcity, unity. Use them honestly.	*“Companies like yours usually start by ____.”* (social proof)
5. Trusted advisor	Let’s Get Real	Move off the solution . Get to the truth fast; make it safe to say no; walk away if you can’t help.	<i>“Before I pitch anything — is this even worth solving right now?”</i>
6. Close & negotiate	Never Split the Difference	Tactical empathy. Label emotions, ask calibrated How/What questions, chase “ <i>That’s right,</i> ” never split the difference.	<i>“It sounds like the risk is what’s holding you back.” → “How would you like to proceed?”</i>

The five things I most often get wrong

Watch for these:

1. Talking when I should be asking. (*Discovery*)
2. Pitching features before I've developed the need. (*SPIN*)
3. Needing the deal too much — desperation repels. (*Fanatical Prospecting's Law of Need*)
4. Pushing for “yes” instead of getting comfortable with “no.” (*Voss*)
5. Skipping prospecting on good weeks, then starving 90 days later. (*The 30-Day Rule*)

The universal frame

Diagnose before you prescribe. A doctor who prescribes before diagnosing is committing malpractice. So is a seller who pitches before diagnosing.

The Stage Playbook

Build the Pipeline

Source: *Fanatical Prospecting*, Jeb Blount

Core idea

The #1 reason for failure in sales is an empty pipe, and the #1 reason for an empty pipe is the failure to prospect. Prospecting is the unglamorous work that makes everything downstream easy. You don't get to feel like prospecting — you prospect *anyway*.

The laws that keep me honest

- **The 30-Day Rule.** The prospecting you do in any 30-day window pays off for the *next 90 days*. Corollary: the slump you create by skipping this week shows up three months from now, when you can't trace it back. This is why prospecting is non-negotiable even when the current pipeline looks full.
- **The Law of Replacement.** Every deal that leaves the pipe (won *or* lost) must be replaced. A closed deal is a hole in the pipeline, not a reason to celebrate and coast.
- **The Universal Law of Need.** The more you *need* a deal, the less likely you are to get it. Desperation leaks into your voice, your discounting, your over-explaining. A full pipeline is the only real cure for commission breath.

The daily habit

Block a fixed, protected window — the “Golden Hours” — for prospecting, and defend it like a customer meeting. Use the “Platinum Hours” (early morning / after hours) for admin and research so the Golden Hours stay pure. Balance across channels rather than betting on one: phone, email, social, referrals, warm intros, in-person. Phone still converts fastest per touch; social builds familiarity *before* the interrupt so the cold call is a little warmer.

The 5-step phone framework

For the interrupt call:

1. **Get their attention** — use their name.
2. **Identify yourself and your company** — briefly.
3. **Tell them why you're calling** — the reason, stated plainly.

4. **Bridge** — a benefit or reason that earns the next 30 seconds.
5. **Ask for exactly what you want** — the meeting. Assume it. “*Do you have your calendar open?*” Don’t trail off; make the ask and stop talking.

Objections vs. brush-offs

Most first-call resistance (“I’m busy,” “send me an email,” “we’re all set”) is a *reflex*, not a real objection. Have a calm, pre-scripted turnaround ready so the reflex doesn’t end the call. Real objections come later, after interest.

The three enemies (the 3 Ps)

Procrastination, Perfectionism, and Paralysis from over-analysis. All three are solved by the same thing — *action*. The way out of call reluctance is not to feel better first; it’s to make the call and let confidence follow.

Founder tuning

As a founder, your unfair advantage in prospecting is *authenticity and access* — you can send a real, personal note that no SDR could, and you can get meetings on the strength of “I built this because I had your problem.” Your disadvantage is that prospecting is the first thing you drop when you get busy building. Protect the block anyway. Warm intros from your network will out-convert cold outreach 5:1 — mine them systematically before you go cold.

When it’s going wrong

Pipeline dries up in ~90-day cycles; you feel it as a “sudden” slow month. That’s a prospecting-discipline problem from a quarter ago, not a closing problem today.

Run Discovery

Source: *SPIN Selling*, Neil Rackham

Core idea

Based on research across ~35,000 sales calls: in *large, complex* sales, the seller who asks the right questions in the right order wins — and classic “always be closing” tactics actively *hurt*. Discovery isn’t a phase before selling. In a complex sale, discovery *is* the selling.

The SPIN sequence

Four question types, in order:

1. **Situation questions** — facts about their current state (“What are you using now? How’s the team structured?”). Necessary but *low value* and tiresome. Do your homework first so you ask few of these and only the ones you couldn’t Google.
2. **Problem questions** — probe difficulties and dissatisfactions (“Where does that process break down? What’s frustrating about the current tool?”). These surface *implied needs* — hints of pain.
3. **Implication questions** — the power move, and the hardest. Take a problem and expand its consequences until the buyer *feels its true size* (“So when that breaks, what does it cost you downstream? How does that affect the rest of the team / the quarter / the customer?”). Implication questions turn a small annoyance into an expensive, urgent problem — in the buyer’s own words.
4. **Need-payoff questions** — get the buyer to articulate the *value of solving it* (“If you could fix that, what would it be worth? How would that help?”). Now the buyer is selling themselves. This builds positive energy and pre-empts objections, because people don’t argue with their own conclusions.

Implied vs. explicit needs

An implied need is a complaint (“it’s slow”). An explicit need is a stated want (“I need something faster”). In small sales, implied needs are enough to close. In large sales, you must *develop* implied needs into explicit ones — and Implication + Need-payoff questions are the machine that does it.

Features, Advantages, Benefits

Features and advantages fall flat early. **Benefits** — capabilities tied to an *explicit need the buyer has already stated* — are what move large sales. This is why order matters: benefits only land after need-payoff.

The counterintuitive finding on closing

Rackham’s data showed that traditional closing techniques *reduce* success in large sales (they work only in small transactional ones). Instead of “closing,” aim for an **Advance** — a concrete action that moves the deal forward (a scheduled next meeting with the economic buyer, a pilot, access to a stakeholder) — versus a **Continuation** (a vague “we’ll be in touch”) that is really a polite no.

Founder tuning

Founders love their solution and reflexively demo too early. SPIN is the antidote: bite your tongue, and don’t show the product until the buyer has articulated an explicit need it fills. Your product knowledge is a weapon *after* discovery, not a substitute for it.

When it’s going wrong

You’re doing most of the talking; you demoed in the first ten minutes; the buyer is politely nodding but hasn’t said out loud what the problem costs them.

Create Demand Through Insight

Source: *The Challenger Sale*, Dixon & Adamson

Core idea

The research sorted reps into five profiles — Hard Worker, Relationship Builder, Lone Wolf, Reactive Problem Solver, and **Challenger**. In complex solution sales, Challengers dominate and pure Relationship Builders underperform. A Challenger wins by **Teach, Tailor, Take Control**:

- **Teach** the customer something new and provocative about *their own business* — an insight they'd pay for even without buying from you.
- **Tailor** that message to the specific stakeholder's economic drivers and KPIs.
- **Take control** of the conversation — comfortable talking about money and comfortable with a little constructive tension.

Commercial Teaching — the six-step pitch that reframes

1. **The Warmer** — open by showing you understand their world and their challenges (earn the right to teach). *Not* about you yet.
2. **The Reframe** — deliver a surprising insight that recategorizes the problem. This is the hinge of the whole sale. (“The real issue isn't X, it's Y — and Y is costing you more than X ever did.”)
3. **Rational Drowning** — quantify it. Build the business case with data until the status quo feels genuinely uncomfortable.
4. **Emotional Impact** — make them see *themselves* in the story. “This is you. This is what it's costing your team.” Move it from abstract to personal.
5. **A New Way** — describe the ideal solution *as a set of requirements*, before naming yourself. Get them nodding at the criteria.
6. **Your Solution / Value Prop** — now show that you are uniquely best at delivering that new way. The insight must lead *back to your strength* — teaching that points anywhere is just charity.

Target the Mobilizer, not the Talker

(From the follow-up work, *The Challenger Customer*.) In a group buying decision, build consensus through **Mobilizers** — Go-Getters, Teachers, and Skeptics who can drive change internally — rather than the friendly **Talkers** who give you great meetings and no traction.

The honest caution (why I keep this consultative)

Challenger’s “take control” can curdle into pushiness, and its insight-led opening can feel like a lecture if you haven’t earned it. I use the *Teach* and *Reframe* — genuinely valuable to the buyer — but I ground the “control” in Khalsa’s intent (see Chapter): I’m assertive *on their behalf*, not to force my agenda. Insight that serves the buyer builds trust; insight deployed to trap them destroys it. When in doubt, err toward the trusted-advisor posture.

Founder tuning

This is a founder’s home turf. You have a point of view about the market — that *is* the reframe. The insight you built the company around is your commercial teaching pitch. Sharpen it into steps 1–6 and you have a demand-creation engine most reps can’t replicate, because they don’t actually believe anything. You do.

When it’s going wrong

Your “insight” is really just a feature list; the buyer already knew everything you “taught” them; you’re creating tension without having earned credibility first.

Understand Buying Psychology

Source: *Influence*, Robert Cialdini — the cross-cutting lens.

Core idea

People say yes for predictable reasons. These aren't a stage — they run *underneath* all the other stages. Use them as a detective uncovering *genuine* strengths, never as a con manufacturing fake ones. Cialdini is emphatic: the “smugglers” who fabricate these signals get caught and pay for it. Ethical persuasion surfaces truth that's already there.

The seven principles, with a founder's use

1. **Reciprocity** — people repay what they receive. *Give first*: a genuinely useful teardown, an intro, a piece of insight (see Chapter). The gift must be meaningful, unexpected, and customized.
2. **Commitment & Consistency** — people act consistently with prior commitments, especially active, public, written ones. Secure small yeses early; get agreement on the problem and the criteria before the price conversation. Written recap emails work *because* of this.
3. **Social proof** — people follow similar others, especially under uncertainty. “Companies like yours,” named case studies, logos, usage numbers, testimonials from a lookalike buyer. Specific and similar beats big and generic.
4. **Authority** — we defer to credible experts. Demonstrate real expertise; show the trappings honestly (results, credentials, the insight itself). A trust-building trick: admit a small, genuine weakness *before* your strength — it makes the strength believable.
5. **Liking** — we say yes to people we like. Drivers: similarity, sincere compliments, and cooperation toward a *shared* goal. Find the real common ground; don't fake rapport.
6. **Scarcity** — we want what's less available, and we're more moved by *loss* than gain. Honest scarcity only: real deadlines, limited onboarding slots, genuine cost-of-delay. Frame the cost of *not* acting (loss aversion) — but never invent urgency.
7. **Unity** — the strongest and newest: shared *identity*. Not “people like you” but “*we*.” Category (“founders like us”), shared mission, shared enemy. The more the buyer feels you're on the same team, the less you have to persuade at all.

How this layers onto the other stages

Reciprocity and authority power your *prospecting* (Chapter) and *teaching* (Chapter); consistency powers *discovery* (getting explicit needs on record, Chapter); social proof and unity power *trust* (Chapter); scarcity and loss-aversion power the *close* (Chapter).

When it's going wrong

Any principle used to create a false impression. If it wouldn't survive the buyer finding out how you did it, don't do it. The whole point of leading with trusted-advisor intent is that these levers then work *for* you honestly.

Sell as a Trusted Advisor

Source: *Let's Get Real or Let's Not Play*, Mahan Khalsa & Randy Illig

Core idea

The seller's job is to *help the client succeed* — full stop. If you can genuinely help, the sale takes care of itself; if you can't, the honorable and profitable move is to say so and walk. This posture is what makes everything else non-sleazy. It's also, counterintuitively, the fastest path to revenue, because it kills bad deals early and deepens good ones.

The core moves

- **Intent counts more than technique.** Buyers can feel whether you're solving for *their* success or your quota. Lead with the former and the techniques land; lead with the latter and even good technique feels slimy. Set the intent explicitly at the start of a conversation.
- **Move off the solution.** The instinct — especially for a founder — is to leap to “here's what we do.” Resist it. Explore the client's world thoroughly *before* proposing anything. Premature solutions signal that you care about selling, not helping, and they anchor the conversation on the wrong thing.
- **Make it safe to tell the truth — “let's get real.”** Actively invite the “no.” Remove false positives (the polite enthusiasm that wastes months). “*If at any point this isn't a fit, I'd genuinely rather you tell me — it saves us both.*” A fast, honest no is worth more than a slow maybe.
- **Get to the metrics.** Vague problems don't get funded. For every issue, quantify it: what's the **evidence** (how would you even measure this?), the **impact** (what is it worth in dollars / time / risk?), the **context**, and the **constraints**? “You're paid to think, not to have all the answers” — so ask, don't assume. No fuzzy language: when they say “a lot” or “soon,” pin it down — “*How much, exactly? By when, exactly?*”
- **Understand the whole decision.** Who decides, what the criteria are, what the process and timeline look like, what budget and resources exist. Missing this is how “sure deals” die in procurement.
- **Mutual benefit or no deal.** You're an equal, choosing whether to work together — not a supplicant. That stance, paradoxically, is what earns trust and advisory status.

Founder tuning

Your credibility as an advisor is *higher* than any rep's — you built the thing, you understand the problem deeply, and you can afford to disqualify because you're optimizing for the right customers, not this month's number. Use that. Being willing to tell a prospect “honestly, you don't need us yet” is the single most trust-building move available to a founder, and those prospects come back.

When it's going wrong

You're pitching before you've diagnosed; you can't state the dollar impact of the problem you're solving; you're chasing a “maybe” you should have disqualified; you're afraid to say the hard true thing.

Close and Negotiate

Source: *Never Split the Difference*, Chris Voss

Core idea

From an FBI hostage negotiator: negotiation is not logical argument, it's *tactical empathy* — understanding and voicing the other side's perspective and emotions so thoroughly that they feel heard, which is what actually moves them. You are not trying to be right; you are trying to get to a decision. And you never “split the difference” — a compromise between two positions is usually lose-lose.

The toolkit

- **Tactical empathy** — deeply understand *and articulate* the other side's feelings and viewpoint. Not agreement; demonstrated understanding.
- **Labeling** — name their emotion out loud: “*It seems like the timing is a concern,*” “*It sounds like you've been burned before,*” “*It looks like budget is the real issue.*” Labeling a fear diffuses it; labeling a positive reinforces it.
- **Accusation audit** — preempt every negative they might be thinking before they say it: “*You're probably thinking this is too expensive, that we're too small to trust, that switching is a headache...*” Saying it first defuses it.
- **Mirroring** — repeat the last one-to-three words they said, as a question. It keeps them talking and reveals more, and it costs you nothing.
- **Get to “No,” not “Yes.”** “Yes” is a commitment people fear; “No” makes them feel safe and in control. Ask no-oriented questions: “*Is now a bad time?*” “*Have you given up on solving this?*” A “no” opens the real conversation.
- **Chase “That's right,” not “You're right.”** When they say “*That's right,*” you've genuinely captured their reality and the breakthrough is near. “*You're right*” is a polite brush-off that means nothing. Engineer summaries that earn a “that's right.”
- **Calibrated questions** — open questions starting with **How** or **What** that give them the illusion of control while making them solve your problem: “*How am I supposed to do that?*” “*What's the biggest challenge you're facing?*” “*How would you like to proceed?*” Avoid “why” (feels accusatory).
- **The Ackerman close** (systematic bargaining): decide your target; open at **65%** of your ceiling; raise in decreasing increments (**85%, 95%, 100%**); use *precise, non-round* numbers (they feel calculated and firm); throw in a small non-monetary extra at the end; and use empathy + “how”-questions to let them feel they fought for it.

- **Hunt the Black Swan** — the piece of hidden information that, once uncovered, changes the whole negotiation. Assume it exists and stay curious enough to find it.
- **Delivery** — the calm, downward-inflected “late-night FM DJ voice” signals control and safety. 7-38-55: tone and body language carry more than words, so *how* you say it matters as much as *what*.

Founder tuning

Founders tend to over-argue value and cave on price out of eagerness (the Law of Need again). Voss flips it: stop persuading, start empathizing; get comfortable letting the buyer say “no”; and hold your price with a calibrated question (“*How am I supposed to make the numbers work at that?*”) instead of a reflexive discount. Your enthusiasm is an asset in Chapter and a liability here — cool it down for the close.

When it’s going wrong

You’re arguing facts instead of labeling feelings; you asked for “yes” and got yes-but-no; you split the difference to end the discomfort; you discounted before they even pushed.

Founder-Led Sales Resources

Beyond the six core books, these are the resources most worth my time as a founder selling my own product. Grouped by what they're best for.

Talking to customers honestly

(Pairs with SPIN + Khalsa.)

- **The Mom Test — Rob Fitzpatrick.** The single best book on customer conversations. How to ask questions that get you the truth even when everyone is being nice to you. Antidote to the founder's habit of fishing for compliments instead of facts. **Read this first.**

The founder-led sales canon

- **Founding Sales — Pete Kazanjy** (free at foundingsales.com). The definitive handbook for the founder who has to sell before there's a sales team: mindset, process, first hires, tooling. Comprehensive and practical.
- **YC Startup School — “How to Sell” (Tyler Bosmeny, founder of Clever).** ~30-min talk. The founder sales funnel — prospecting → conversion → closing — and why founders are actually *better* first salespeople than pros (passion + product depth). Watch it.
- **Steli Efti / Close blog — “The Startup’s Guide to Outbound Sales.”** Scrappy, tactical founder-sales content; especially good on follow-up persistence.

Positioning

(Upstream of all selling — fix this and every stage gets easier.)

- **Obviously Awesome — April Dunford.** How to position your product so buyers instantly get why it's for them. If discovery keeps stalling on “I don't get what this is,” the problem is positioning, not pitching.

Problem-centric selling

(A modern, founder-friendly complement to SPIN + Challenger.)

- **Gap Selling — Keenan.** Sell the *gap* between the customer’s current state and desired future state, quantified. Reinforces “diagnose before you prescribe” with a crisp, current framework. Very compatible with everything above.

Scaling past founder-led

(For later — don’t over-optimize early.)

- **Predictable Revenue — Aaron Ross.** The outbound/SDR model (“Cold Calling 2.0”) and specialized sales roles. Where to look when you’re ready to build a repeatable machine beyond yourself.
- **From Impossible to Inevitable — Aaron Ross & Jason Lemkin,** and **SaaStr (Jason Lemkin)** generally. When and how to make your first sales hires and move from founder-led to a team. Read when you have repeatable, self-sourced revenue — not before.
- **The Sales Acceleration Formula — Mark Roberge (HubSpot).** Building a data-driven, repeatable sales org. Also a “later” book.

Essays worth bookmarking

- **Paul Graham — “Do Things That Don’t Scale.”** The philosophical license for founder-led sales: recruiting your first customers by hand is not a hack, it’s the job.
- **First Round Review & Lenny’s Newsletter** — search “founder-led sales” and “first sales hire.” Steady stream of concrete playbooks from operators.

Suggested reading order

The Mom Test → *Obviously Awesome* → *Founding Sales* → then the Bosmeny talk → then *Gap Selling*. Save the “scaling” books for when founder-led sales is already working.

The Weekly Operating Cadence

Knowledge you don't run on a schedule is just trivia. Here's how I actually operate this system.

Daily (30–60 min, protected — the “Golden Hour”)

- **Prospecting block.** Non-negotiable, even in a good week (the 30-Day Rule, Chapter). Mix warm intros, personalized outbound, and follow-ups. Make the calls *first*, before email pulls me under.

Per live deal

- **Before every call:** re-read the **cheat sheet**. Write the *one* reframe (Chapter) and the *three* implication questions (Chapter) I'll use.
- **During discovery:** talk <40% of the time. Don't demo until I hear an *explicit* need. Get the dollar impact on the record (Chapter).
- **After every call:** send a recap email that states the problem, its quantified impact, and the agreed next step (locks in commitment/consistency, Chapter). Confirm an **Advance**, not a vague continuation.

Weekly deal review (30 min, solo or with a peer)

For each open deal, answer four questions honestly:

1. Can I state the **dollar impact** of the problem I'm solving for them? (*If no → back to discovery.*)
2. Do I know the **full decision process** — who, criteria, timeline, budget? (*If no → I have a diagnosis gap.*)
3. What's the **next Advance**, and is it scheduled? (*If no → it's a continuation, i.e. a soft no.*)
4. Should I **disqualify** this? (*Would saying “you don't need us yet” be the honest call?*)

Then: is my pipeline being *replaced* as fast as it's emptying? (Law of Replacement.)

Monthly

- Review win/loss patterns. Which reframe (Chapter) actually lands? Which objection recurs — and is it a positioning problem (fix upstream, Chapter) rather than a selling problem?
- Sharpen the commercial teaching pitch based on what real buyers said “that’s right” to.

Diagnose before you prescribe. Prospect before you’re empty. Ask before you pitch. Teach something true. Lead with their success. And never split the difference.